Causes

Decline of Feudalism

Under the feudal system, the medieval kings were at the mercy of their nobles who were prepared to align with the king's enemies at any time. The kings had no control over the vassal lands, as the nobles had their own sub vassals and army to protect them. This weakened the position and power of the kings. The plague that struck Europe in medieval time weakened the nobility. As thousands of peasants died, the nobility lost their work force and their taxes too. Nobles died in large numbers during the course of Crusades. The decline of feudalism was a decisive factor in enabling the new rising monarchy to assert itself.

New warfare techniques such as use of gunpowder also contributed to the changes. The weakening war strategy of the knights came to the forefront during the Thirty Years War. The English longbow along with gunpowder caused more damage than the mounted knights.

Growing Unpopularity of the Church

During the medieval period, the Church was the dominant institution. It had large tracts of lands under its control. Church establishments such as monasteries, convents and buildings acquired more land, which were exempted from taxes. Further the church imposed tithe, 10% of the total produce, as a tax levied on the people under its jurisdiction. The Church became wealthier than the state. Through its economic and religious power, the Church assumed greater significance than the kings. The Church had its own justice system too. Ecclesiastical courts were set up to punish erring church officials such as the bishops, priests and nuns. The royal courts could not try them. Ecclesiastical courts had more power than the courts of the kings. This further undermined the power of the kings. Excommunication was a powerful punishment exercised by the Pope to humiliate the king in front of his nobles and subjects. Henry IV of Germany was excommunicated by Pope Gregory VII for not respecting his ordinances. The kings could not, therefore, antagonise the church. But the Black Death weakened the position of the church as it could not explain the causes for the Black Death. The authority of Pope came to be increasingly challenged by many of the early dissenters.



Pope Gregory VII

Spain as Nation-State

Major parts of Spain were under the control of the Moors, Muslim Saracens, the descendants of the Arab conquerors. There were two important kingdoms: Aragon and Castile. A turning point in the history of Spain was the King Ferdinand of Aragon marrying Queen Isabella of Castile. Together they worked hard to drive away the Moors and unite Spain. The king and queen took power in their hands (1479) and controlled the nobles by eliminating them from the royal councils. Spain emerged as a nation state.

Both Ferdinand and Isabella who jointly ruled Spain were devout Catholics. During the rule of the Moors, the Jews who controlled the economy of Spain enjoyed considerable freedom. Now, the Moors and the Jews were forced to convert to Christianity. The king setup the Spanish Inquisition through which the Jew and Moor converts were kept in strict vigil. Many non-believers were tried, tortured and burnt at the stake. The royal house became more powerful than the church.

The discovery of the sea route to Americas by Columbus and the conquest of Inca and Aztec empires by the Spaniards brought enormous wealth. This made Spain prosperous, and it began to play a leading part in European politics.

England as Nation-State

There was conflict between two royal houses in England namely the House of York and House of Lancaster for the throne. This led to the War of the Roses. (They wore badges of white rose and red rose respectively, hence the name.)

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